

Virginia Woolf: Modernist And Feminist [B2]

È stata una delle menti più brillanti e innovative della letteratura inglese. Col suo linguaggio sperimentale, rivoluzionario per l'epoca, ha affrontato temi tabù come il ruolo della donna nella società, le convenzioni di genere e le ferite invisibili della guerra.



Born in 1882, the novelist, essayist, diarist and letter writer Virginia Woolf was one of the most influential writers in English of the last century. Famous for helping to pioneer [stream-of-consciousness](#) narration as a [literary device](#), she was also a prominent figure in Modernism: the cultural, literary and artistic movement which broke with traditions, and prioritised experimentation, abstraction and subjective experiences.

SOCIETY PARENTS

Virginia's parents, Leslie Stephen and Julia Duckworth, both on second marriages, were society figures. Denied access to school or university because of her gender, Virginia educated herself in her father's impressive library. An idyllic childhood ended when Julia died in 1895, sending Virginia into a severe depression. In 1897, her half-sister Stella Duckworth also died, followed in 1904 by Virginia's father. Virginia then attempted suicide. Her brother Thoby died two years later. Virginia would suffer with mental [instability](#) all her life, possibly partly [due to](#) the sexual abuse she suffered from her half-brother Gerald. The act of writing helped her. Virginia Woolf.

BLOOMSBURY GROUP

In 1904, Virginia and her remaining family moved to the bohemian Bloomsbury district of London. She became a founding member of the Bloomsbury Group, an influential [gathering](#) of writers, intellectuals, philosophers, and artists who challenged social conventions. There she met the writer Leonard Woolf, whom she would marry in 1912. His love and support were fundamental in allowing her to write. People

Jane Austen: Iconic Literary Figure È l'autrice di lingua inglese più letta al mondo e la sua opera ha ispirato innumerevoli adattamenti. Maestra nell'arte del dialogo e acuta osservatrice delle relazioni umane, ha contribuito a fare del romanzo uno dei generi di intrattenimento più popolari. Conor Gleeson , Sarah Davison

REVIEWS AND ARTICLES

Woolf began writing anonymous reviews and articles of literary criticism for various [journals](#) in 1908. In 1917, she and Leonard started their own [printing press](#) and [publishing house](#), Hogarth Press, which would publish her works and those by T. S. Eliot, Katherine Mansfield and E. M. Forster. She began to write her first novel, [The Voyage Out](#), but again attempted suicide.

Words, English words, are full of echoes, memories, associations, naturally. They've [BEEN OUT AND ABOUT](#), on people's lips, in their houses, in the streets, in the fields, for so many centuries.

RADICAL CHANGE

Woolf began her journey to radically change English fiction in 1922 with *Jacob's Room*. Trying to write in a new, modern way to reflect a rapidly-modernising world, she transformed her [grief](#) over her brother Thoby's death into a "spiritual shape". The [breakthrough](#) novel relates the protagonist Jacob's life and early death in war, but it omits [plot](#) and even character to create the [emptiness](#) of loss.

RECOGNITION

Her next two books [cemented](#) Woolf's reputation as a literary [ground-breaker](#). In *Mrs. Dalloway* (1925) Woolf considers the moral dilemma of war and its mental effects on soldiers returning from the First World War. Using an innovative, non-linear, [stream-of-consciousness](#) technique, she combines the story of an upper-class woman, Clarissa Dalloway, who is planning a party, with the life of a soldier suffering from hallucinations and [haunting](#) memories. Nicole Kidman as Virginia Woolf in *The Hours* (2002), a performance that earned her the Oscar for Best Actress.

TO THE LIGHTHOUSE

In [To the Lighthouse](#) (1927), a tale of love, [legacy](#) and loss modelled on her own family, with radical representations of time, Woolf uses the same technique to explore memory and the subconscious, filtering experiences through a character's perceptions. Equally radical is the [gender-bending](#) *Orlando* (1928), where the protagonist lives from Elizabethan times into the 20th century, changing identities and sex along the way. In *The Waves* (1931), Woolf experimented with collective consciousness, [collapsing six characters into](#) one.

The history of men's opposition to women's emancipation is more interesting perhaps than the story of that emancipation itself.

A FEMINIST CLASSIC

By the end of the 1920s, Woolf was a celebrated public intellectual, even appearing on the cover of *Time* magazine and dressed by the editor of *Vogue*. In 1929, she published her most famous essay, *A Room of One's Own*, one of the most influential feminist writings in history. Concentrating on women and literature, Woolf attributed women's artistic absence from history and history books not to

a [lack](#) of intelligence or talent, but to their poverty and confined lives. She describes a world denied great works of art because of exclusion and inequality.

MENTAL DECLINE

Woolf continued writing in the 1930s, but the Second World War proved to be a disaster for her mental health. Seriously depressed, doubting her [ability](#) to write, and afraid she was going mad, Woolf walked to the River Ouse near her house on 28 March 1941, put a large rock in her pocket, and [drowned herself](#). Fighting against mental illness much of her life, Woolf had still managed through her writing to fundamentally change literary norms and to challenge society's centuries-old ideas about what it meant to be a woman.

THE WOOLF STYLE

Woolf's literary style was radically new, but it could be confusing at times. As well as her famous [stream-of-consciousness](#) device, she employed interior monologues, distortions in time, and multiple or [shifting](#) (or "multiple") perspectives. Who exactly is talking? Her immersive narratives move between [inner](#) and [outer](#) worlds, people's thoughts and their external experiences, and sometimes the divisions are not clear. However, her radically-innovative style helps readers see the world in a completely fresh way. At the same time, [plot](#) is much less important, while simple, everyday things become fascinating. Woolf also had a grammatical [quirk](#): she loved to use [semi-colons](#) to express contradictory thoughts in the same sentence. Interestingly, she began *A Room of One's Own* with the word 'But'!

A ROOM OF HER OWN

Considered one of the foundational essays in feminist literary history, Woolf's work is a brilliantly-written attack on the general invisibility of women in history. Concentrating specifically on the literary side of life, she famously wrote that "a woman must have money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction." She shows her brilliance by imagining a fictional sister for Shakespeare, Judith, possessed of a genius similar to Britain's greatest poet. In this thought experiment, simply by being a woman, Judith's life is so restricted by social norms that she can never [realise](#) her genius. Looking back through time for [hints](#) of hidden histories, Woolf also imagines the possibility of "a lost novelist, a suppressed poet, of some [mute](#) and inglorious Jane Austen." But Woolf also goes beyond just literature to consider the missing role of women in history in general. One famous section begins: "With the eye of the imagination I saw a very ancient lady crossing the street." Woolf then imagines hypothetically asking her about specific dates in her distant past, and the old lady replying "that she could remember nothing." The

voice of Woolf continues, “For all the [dinner](#)s are cooked; the plates and cups washed; the children sent to school and gone out into the world. Nothing remains of it all. All has [vanished](#). No biography or history has a word to say about it. And the novels, [without meaning to](#), inevitably lie.” With angry, accusatory sadness, Woolf concludes, “All these infinitely obscure lives remain to be recorded.” One British academic has called Woolf’s work “probably the most important and influential woman’s essay ever written, at least for Western culture.”

Glossary

- **The Voyage Out** = “La crociera”
- **emptiness** = vuoto
- **haunting** = inquietanti
- **collapsing six characters into** = fondere in
- **outer** = esteriore
- **quirk** = peculiarità, vezzo
- **stream-of-consciousness** = flusso di coscienza
- **journals** = periodici, riviste
- **shifting** = mutevoli
- **semi-colons** = punti e virgola
- **legacy** = eredità
- **without meaning to** = senza volerlo
- **ground-breaker** = innovatrice, pioniera
- **To the Lighthouse** = “Gita al faro”
- **gender-bending** = che sfida le convenzioni di genere
- **literary device** = espediente letterario
- **realise** = sviluppare pienamente
- **vanished** = scomparire
- **breakthrough** = innovativo
- **plot** = trama
- **lack** = mancanza
- **ability** = capacità
- **mute** = muta
- **gathering** = gruppo
- **printing press** = tipografia
- **publishing house** = casa editrice
- **BEEN OUT AND ABOUT** = stare in giro, circolare
- **drowned herself** = farsi annegare
- **inner** = interiore
- **due to** = a causa di
- **grief** = dolore
- **cemented** = consolidare
- **hints** = indizi